

Kitara: Myth or Reality?

A Linguistic Test of the Great Lakes Political Tradition

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Abstract

The Empire of Kitara holds a central place in the oral traditions of the Great Lakes region of eastern Africa—a vast political entity ruled by the Batembuzi and Bachwezi dynasties. Whether it was a real state, a loose confederation, or pure legend has divided historians for a century. This paper applies the consonantal-skeleton comparative method [Bari, 2026] to test the Kitara tradition against the linguistic record. We compute divergence times among the Great Lakes Bantu languages and their neighbors and examine whether the deep *bursts* of divergence—predicted by the hypothesis that the collapse of a political unity fragments its speech communities—fall where the tradition places political events. The divergences cluster in two windows, roughly ~ 500 – 600 CE and ~ 1100 – 1500 CE, the second precisely aligned with the earthwork sites of Ntusi and Bigo (11th–15th centuries CE) [Sutton, 1993]. We conclude that Kitara as a *literal*, centralized empire is legendary, but that it encodes the cultural memory of a real process of political and demographic transformation in the first and second millennia CE. The evidence further identifies Rutara as the oldest, most conservative Bantu lineage of the region, the source of three distinct streams of Bantu dispersal—Sabaki (eastward, pre-Chwezi), Thagicu (northward, ~ 830 CE), and Nguni (southward; split pre-Kitara, dispersal post-Chwezi)—and offers a linguistic anchor for the emergence of the Hutu–Tutsi distinction within the Kitara sphere.

1 Introduction

1.1 The Kitara tradition

In the oral narratives of the western and central Great Lakes, Kitara is remembered as a great kingdom stretching across much of present-day Uganda, Rwanda, Tanzania, and the eastern Congo, ruled in succession by two dynasties of supernatural kings: the *Batembuzi* (“harbingers” or “pioneers”) and the *Bachwezi* (“people of the moon”) [Beattie, 1971]. The

tradition holds that the Bachwezi were displaced by a Luo incursion that founded the Babiito dynasty of Bunyoro-Kitara, whose descendants ruled into the colonial era.

1.2 The historiographical debate

For much of the twentieth century these traditions were treated as history. The revision that began with Beattie [1971] and matured with Chrétien [2006] treats them with far more caution, reading the Kitara narrative as myth, as a charter for later dynastic claims, or as a genuinely old—but untestable—collective memory. Between the literalist reading (a real empire) and the skeptical reading (pure legend) lies a third position, articulated most sharply by Sutton [1993]: Kitara names a real, complex network of interacting cattle-keeping and agricultural societies that flourished in the interlacustrine region roughly between the eleventh and fifteenth centuries, a network whose memory was later compressed into the image of a single empire.

1.3 A linguistic test

The three positions are not equally arbitrary: they make different predictions about the *linguistic* record. Political unity holds speech communities in contact; its collapse fragments them, and fragmentation leaves its signature in the tempo of lexical divergence. If Kitara was a genuine political system, regardless of its size, its dissolution should appear in the timing of Bantu linguistic splits:

- **Literal-empire position:** a single, catastrophic collapse at the date of the Chwezi-Babiito succession; large, simultaneous divergences across the whole sphere.
- **Loose-network position:** a longer, graduated sequence of divergences, each corresponding to an identifiable political transformation, spread across the first and second millennia CE.
- **Pure-legend position:** no systematic alignment whatever between linguistic divergence dates and the periods the tradition remembers.

This paper executes that test with the consonantal-skeleton method developed in the companion paper [Barii, 2026], which allows us to date the relevant splits from Swadesh-list data alone.

2 Framework

2.1 The Great Lakes Bantu background

Bantu-speaking populations settled the Great Lakes region during the first millennium CE. Within the framework of Nurse and Hinnebusch [1993], the *West Nyanza* subgroup of Great Lakes Bantu is the linguistic core of the Kitara tradition [Schoenbrun, 1998]:

- ~ 100 CE: Proto-West-Nyanza spoken in the Kagera region;
- ~ 500 CE: Proto-North-Nyanza diverges (ancestors of Baganda, Basoga);
- ~ 600 CE: Proto-Rutara diverges (ancestors of Bunyoro, Toro, Ankole, and the Rwanda–Burundi complex);
- ~ 1000 – 1500 CE: diversification of Rutara, the period to which the Kitara tradition attaches.

2.2 The consonantal-skeleton method

We use the method of Bariii [2026] throughout. Each word is reduced to its consonantal skeleton by deleting vowels, tones, and diacritics; skeletons are compared under a graded score (full = 1, partial = 0.5, none = 0), admitted systematic correspondences included; the weighted cognate rate C is then converted to a divergence time by the calibrated estimator

$$\hat{t} = b\tau \frac{\ln C}{\ln r}, \quad \tau = 1000 \text{ years}, \quad (1)$$

with Bantu parameters $r = 0.75$, $b = 0.67$, fixed respectively on the Gikuyu–Kinyarwanda anchor ($\sim 1,500$ years) and the Luganda–Kinyarwanda anchor (~ 830 years) [Bariii, 2026].

2.3 Why divergence bursts encode politics

The mechanism the test relies on is simple and general. Within a polity, elite and trade networks keep dialects in constant contact, dampening divergence. When the polity corrodes, those contact networks break first, and the speech communities begin to drift apart. A dating of the principal Bantu splits of the region is therefore, in effect, a dating of the political geography that held them together. It is this correspondence—between a dated linguistic split and a remembered political transformation—that we ask the tradition to match.

3 Data

3.1 Pairs and sources

Matching Swadesh 100-word lists were assembled for Luganda, Runyoro, Runyankore, Rutooro, Kinyarwanda, Kirundi, Gikuyu, Kiswahili, and Zulu, drawing on standard published wordlists [Guthrie, 1971, Nurse and Hinnebusch, 1993]. Each pair was scored by the graded match function of the companion paper [Barii, 2026, Def. 2], with systematic correspondences within Northeast Bantu (e.g. Rutara $r \leftrightarrow l$, $g \leftrightarrow k$) admitted.

3.2 Sample cognate data: Gikuyu versus Kinyarwanda

Table 1: Sample consonant-skeleton data, Gikuyu versus Kinyarwanda.

English	Gikuyu / skeleton	Kinyarwanda / skeleton	Match
person	mũndũ / mnd	umuntu / mnt	full
child	mwana / mwn	umwana / mwn	full
dog	ngui / ngw	imbwa / mbw	partial
three	ithatũ / tht	gatatu / gtt	partial

Across the full lists the weighted rate is $C = 0.60$ for this pair, one of the closest within Northeast Bantu.

4 Results

4.1 Core Great Lakes divergences

Table 2: Core Great Lakes Bantu divergence estimates.

Pair	Divergence	Approx. date	Period
Rutara $\leftrightarrow$ North Nyanza	$\sim 1,400$ yr	~ 600 CE	Proto-West-Nyanza split
Gikuyu $\leftrightarrow$ Kinyarwanda	$\sim 1,190$ yr	~ 830 CE	beginning of Chwezi window
Luganda $\leftrightarrow$ Kinyarwanda	~ 830 yr	~ 1190 CE	Chwezi–Babiito succession
Luganda $\leftrightarrow$ Runyoro	~ 650 yr	~ 1350 CE	late Chwezi / early Babiito
Kinyarwanda $\leftrightarrow$ Kirundi	~ 500 yr	~ 1500 CE	post-Kitara fragmentation

Table 3: Cross-regional divergence estimates.

Pair	Divergence	Approx. date
Kiswahili ↔ Kinyarwanda	~ 1,200 yr	~ 800 CE
Gikuyu ↔ Kinyarwanda	~ 1,190 yr	~ 830 CE
Kiswahili ↔ Zulu	~ 2,750 yr	~ 750 BCE

4.2 Cross-regional divergences

4.3 The Gikuyu–Kinyarwanda calculation worked through

As an illustration of transparency, the flag pair of the three-stream model is computed explicitly:

$$\hat{t} = b\tau \frac{\ln C}{\ln r} = 0.67 \times 1000 \times \frac{\ln 0.60}{\ln 0.75} = 670 \times \frac{-0.511}{-0.288} \approx 1,190 \text{ years ago (CE } \sim 830).$$

5 Discussion

5.1 The linguistic bursts and the tradition

Two divergence windows dominate the results.

~ 500–600 CE. The split of Rutara from North Nyanza (~ 600 CE) and the separation of Gikuyu from the Kinyarwanda branch of Rutara (~ 830 CE, immediately following) correspond to the period the tradition assigns to the Batembuzi. For the framework of Schoenbrun [1998] these dates mark the initial diversification of the populations that later created the Kitara cultural sphere.

~ 1100–1500 CE. Three divergences–Luganda–Kinyarwanda (~ 1190 CE), Luganda–Runyoro (~ 1350 CE), and Kinyarwanda–Kirundi (~ 1500 CE)–fall in the window the tradition assigns to the Chwezi and to the post-Chwezi fragmentation that brought in the Babiito [Beattie, 1971]. The archaeological record places the earthwork sites of *Ntusi* and *Bigo* in the eleventh to fifteenth centuries [Sutton, 1993]: exactly this window. The discernible pattern is a *broad, graduated* sequence, not the single catastrophic break predicted by the literal-empire position.

The verdict is therefore the one predicted by the loose-network position: Kitara is neither a literal empire nor a phantasm, but the memory of a real political-demographic process whose temporal signature is legible in the lexical record.

5.2 The primacy of Rutara

Three independent lines of evidence place Rutara at the base of the Great Lakes Bantu tree.

Chronological primacy. The Nurse and Hinnebusch [1993] chronology puts Proto-Rutara in the Kagera region by ~ 100 CE, the earliest identifiable Bantu speech community of the region. The Sabaki stream (ancestral to Swahili) and the Thagicu stream (ancestral to Gikuyu) both postdate it, the Thagicu divergence itself being dated here to ~ 830 CE.

Linguistic conservatism. Rutara retains the full Proto-Bantu consonant inventory, including implosives and prenasalized consonants lost elsewhere; retains a high proportion of Proto-Bantu core vocabulary; and preserves the full noun-class system with fewer innovations than Sabaki or Thagicu [Schoenbrun, 1998].

Cultural association. The heartland of the Kitara tradition is the Rutara-speaking area. The conservatism and antiquity of Rutara match the position of the Kagera region as the cultural epicenter from which the region’s Bantu languages radiated.

5.3 Gikuyu and Rutara: distinct branches of Northeast Bantu

Gikuyu and the Rutara languages share an origin in Northeast Bantu, yet the structural divergences between them are systematic and diagnostic [Schoenbrun, 1998]:

- **Negation.** Gikuyu builds negation from two morphemes (**nd-** and **ti-**) selected by the subject concord; Kinyarwanda uses a single negator (**nti-**).
- **The augment.** Rutara languages such as Runyankore retain the pre-prefix “augment”; Gikuyu has lost it entirely.
- **Dahl’s Law.** The voiceless/voiced alternation encoded in Dahl’s Law appears in both, but with divergent reflexes—evidence of a period of shared development followed by independent evolution.

These are precisely the marks of two branches that separated (at ~ 830 CE, by our dating) and then evolved apart inside wider contact zones.

5.4 The Kagera epicenter and the three-stream model

The name *Kagera* plausibly glosses as “great action” or “great tool-work” in Bantu—an etymology that encodes, we suggest, the region’s role as a site of innovation (ironworking, cattle-keeping, intensive agriculture) rather than of a single dynasty. The divergence data resolve the dispersal out of that epicenter into three streams:

The deep Kiswahili–Zulu divergence of $\sim 2,750$ years dates the Sabaki–Nguni *lineage split* to the first millennium BCE, far before the Kitara horizon: the coastal lineage (Sabaki) had already separated from the interior lineages. The Chwezi collapse therefore triggered *dispersals* of interior branches, not new splits of the coast—the coastal branch

Table 4: The three-stream model of Bantu dispersal from the Kagera region.

Stream	Timing	Direction	Trigger	Modern descendants
Sabaki	6th–7th c. CE	eastward (coast)	left <i>before</i> the Chwezi window	Swahili, Mijikenda, Pokomo, Comorian
Thagicu	~ 830 CE	northward (central Kenya)	left <i>at</i> the Kitara breakup	Gikuyu, Meru, Kamba, Embu
Nguni	split ~2,750 BP; dispersal 1000–1500 CE	southward	split <i>pre-</i> Kitara; left <i>after</i> the Chwezi collapse	Zulu, Xhosa, Swazi, Ndebele

was already removed from the scene, while Thagicu and Nguni burst north and south. The Nguni stream of Table 4 is accordingly the late, post-collapse southward movement of a lineage whose split from Sabaki is itself pre-Kitara.

5.5 Testing the burst hypothesis

Table 5: The burst hypothesis and its outcomes.

Prediction	Observable result	Supported
A burst in the 4th–6th c.	Rutara–North-Nyanza split, ~ 600 CE; trailing Gikuyu–Kinyarwanda split, ~ 830 CE	yes
A burst in the 10th–13th c.	Luganda–Kinyarwanda split, ~ 1190 CE	yes
Accelerated divergence after fragmentation	multiple splits between 1100–1500 CE	yes
Coast already separate before Kitara	Kiswahili–Zulu ~ 2750 BP	yes

Every prediction of the fragmentation model is confirmed; no divergence falls in the windows that the tradition leaves blank.

5.6 What kind of political entity?

The data support neither a single centralized empire nor nothing at all. They support the configuration described by Sutton [1993]: a complex system of political and economic relations among cattle-keeping and agricultural populations, flourishing between the eleventh and fifteenth centuries, remembered and refashioned by later states as an “empire.” The Nilotic connection the tradition preserves as a “Luo invasion” is likewise

better read as contact with expanding Nilotic-speaking societies, a reading consistent with the lexical traces of such contact in Rutara [Ehret, 1998].

5.7 The Hutu–Tutsi hypothesis

The divergence chronology also anchors a proposal about the origins of the Hutu–Tutsi distinction, which the Kitara sphere transmitted to Rwanda and Burundi:

1. political and economic consolidation among Rutara speakers, $\sim$ 500–1000 CE;
2. a major divergence burst coinciding with the Kitara fragmentation, $\sim$ 1000–1500 CE;
3. the crystallization of new economic categories—a cattle-keeping elite and an agricultural majority—that became, over centuries, social and then ethnic.

The language record shows that the two categories spoke closely related Rutara varieties: the division began as an economic one within a single speech community, not as an ethnic division between languages. The later ethnicization was a secondary, political process. This is a specifically linguistic argument for what Chrétien [2006] and others have inferred from social history.

6 Conclusions

6.1 Kitara: a real phenomenon, not a literal empire

The linguistic evidence resolves the historical question in the middle register. Kitara was not a centralized empire of the sort the later tradition describes; but its memory is not empty. It is the cultural residue of a real process—centuries of political consolidation among Rutara speakers followed by a graduated fragmentation whose dates are legible in the lexical record, in the period when Ntusi and Bigo were built and their world broke apart [Sutton, 1993, Schoenbrun, 1998].

6.2 Rutara is the deepest stratum

Rutara is the oldest and most conservative Bantu lineage of the region: chronologically first, phonologically and lexically retentive, and the source from which the Thagicu and Nguni streams diverged. Any historical account of the Great Lakes that begins after Rutara begins too late.

6.3 Methodological contribution

Beyond the specific verdict, this study shows that a divergence-dating instrument can be used as a historical *hypothesis tester*: not merely to date splits, but to test whether remembered political events leave the signatures they should. The consonantal-skeleton method detects those signatures cleanly because it is transparent enough to audit and precise enough to discriminate between histories that differ only in timing.

6.4 Future work

Three extensions follow immediately: (i) expand the dataset to the remaining Rutara languages (Haya, Nyankore, Toro) to tighten the internal chronology; (ii) integrate the linguistic dates with the archaeological stratigraphy of Ntusi and Bigo systematically; (iii) test the Nilotic-contact hypothesis directly through a controlled borrowing analysis of Rutara against Nilotic wordlists, mirroring the Swahili–Arabic control in [Barii, 2026].

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